

STUDY GUIDE UNSC



Agenda : De-escalating Tensions in the
Middle East with Special Emphasis on
Non-state Actors





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Agenda: De-escalating Tensions in the Middle East with Special Emphasis on Non-state Actors

COMMITTEE OVERVIEW

What is the UNSC?

The UNSC (United Nations Security Council) is one of the main organs of the United Nations which is responsible for maintaining peace and security throughout the globe. According to the United Nations Charter, the Security Council has four main purposes.

- To maintain international peace and security;
- To develop friendly relations among nations;
- To cooperate in solving international problems and in promoting respect for human rights;
- To be a centre for harmonising the actions of nations.

While other organs of the UN are responsible for recommending solutions to global issues, the Security Council is responsible for accepting and passing solutions, which the member nations are obligated to adhere to.

Mandate of the UNSC

Powers of the UNSC

The United Nations Charter establishes 3 sets of powers for the Security Council, which are;¹

- Adjustment or Settlement powers
- Enforcement powers
- Regional Arrangement powers

In addition, the UNSC has the authority to use force whenever necessary to maintain international peace and security. It can conduct research and fact-finding excursions to gather important information about the potential

threats, which can help it make informed decisions.

Legalities of the UNSC

The Security Council has primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security.

Some of its actions have international law implications, such as those that relate to peacekeeping missions, ad hoc tribunals, and sanctions. The binding nature of resolutions adopted under Chapter VII of the UN Charter is particularly relevant in this case.²

If the council cannot reach a consensus or a passing vote on a resolution, they may choose to produce a non-binding presidential statement instead of a resolution. The statements are adopted by consensus. They are meant to apply political pressure – a warning that the Council is paying attention and further action may follow.

Under Article 13(b) of the Rome Statute, the Security Council can refer certain situations to the Prosecutor of the International Criminal Court (ICC), if it appears international crimes (genocide, crimes against humanity, war crimes, the crime of aggression) have been committed.

INTRODUCTION TO THE MIDDLE EAST

Defining the Middle East region

The Middle East is, by most definitions, a region encompassing the Arabian Peninsula, The Levant, Anatolia, Egypt and Persia. Some definitions also include the regions of Northern Africa, Cyprus and Afghanistan.

¹ What is the Security Council? | Security Council. (n.d.). the United Nations. Retrieved October 20, 2024, from <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/content/what-security-council>

² United Nations. (n.d.-a). *UN Research*. United Nations. <https://research.un.org/en/docs/law/sc>

The Middle East consists of Israel, Palestine, Lebanon, Egypt, Turkiye, Jordan, Syria, Iraq, Iran, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, Qatar, United Arab Emirates, Yemen and Oman.

Ethnoreligious Overview of the Middle East

The Middle East is a diverse region, with several ethnicities and religions inhabiting it which have played a massive role in Middle-Eastern politics and have been an important factor in Middle-Eastern history.

The main religions of the Middle East are Islam, Christianity and Judaism, with Islam being the majority. However, two schools of Islam are followed in this region, Sunni and Shia. Sunni Muslims make up a majority of the Middle Eastern population, however, nations like Iran follow Shia Islam as their main religion. Northern Yemen and Bahrain are also hotspots of Shia Islam. Saudi Arabia and Iran have positioned themselves as leaders of the Sunni and Shia schools, and use this pretext to gain more influence in the Middle East. Oman follows its school of Islam, namely the Ibadi school, which precedes both Sunni and Shia Islam. Lebanon has a sizable Christian population, and Israel follows Judaism as their state religion.

The Middle East contains several ethnic groups including Arabs, Persians, Jews, Turks and Kurds. Arabs make up most of the Middle East, speak the Arabic language and mainly live in the Arabian Peninsula, Egypt, Iraq and Syria. Persians are the most common ethnic group in Iran and speak Iranian, whereas Jews live in Israel and speak Hebrew. Turkiye has the highest Turkish population and speaks Turkish. Kurds populate regions such as eastern Anatolia, northern Syria and eastern Iraq and call for the creation of a Kurdish state.

Significance of the Middle East

The Middle East is one of the most strategic locations in the world, politically, economically,

and religiously. There are several reasons for this. One of the primary reasons for the Middle East's importance is that it lies between Europe, Asia and Africa, and is, therefore, a centre for trade. The Middle East is also known for its vast petroleum reserves, particularly in the Persian Gulf. Saudi Arabia has the most oil reserves amongst the Middle-Eastern countries, which include Iran, Iraq, Kuwait, United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Oman, and Yemen. The Middle East is said to contain 48% of all proven oil reserves in the world. The exporting of this oil is what makes up a lot of the Middle East's economy.

The Middle East is also home to several holy sites. Jerusalem, located in Israel holds religious importance to Jews, Christians and Muslims, and the Kaaba, the holiest site of Islam is located in Mecca, Saudi Arabia.

PROXY WARS

Proxy wars are a form of indirect wars between major powers or regional actors but are not fought directly between them. In these kinds of wars, primary actors support opposing factions within conflicts involving third parties, typically smaller nation-states or non-state actors within the state. This method of indirect conflict allows the larger powers to pursue their geopolitical interest over the region whilst maintaining separation from any direct military action in the eyes of the rest of the world and the media. Proxy wars allow major powers to avoid direct military

confrontation, mitigating the risk of escalating into a larger-scale conflict.³

Proxy wars became increasingly prominent in international conflicts during the Cold War (1947-1991). This is when both the United States and the Soviet Union decided to opt for an indirect approach to the conflict because of the looming possibility of the conflict escalating into a nuclear war. This approach resulted in a complex web of conflicts around the globe, with superpowers controlling these conflicts from afar whilst the smaller nations had to bear the brunt of the actions.

The Middle East has been shaped by proxy conflicts, which have significantly influenced its geopolitical and religious dynamics with the rest of the world. Regional powers like Iran, Saudi Arabia, and Turkey had increasingly adopted these proxy strategies, supporting various factions in conflicts such as the Syrian Civil War, the Yemen conflict, and the power struggles in Iraq.

These indirect interventions, however, have had far-reaching consequences. By fuelling existing tensions and introducing new complications, they have contributed to the increasing instability of the region ongoing instability. The web of proxy relationships has created an intricate landscape where local conflicts are often reflections of broader regional rivalries, making resolution efforts challenging.

This strategy of indirect involvement also prolongs conflict and exacerbates humanitarian crises in the region. As a result, proxies continue to be a double-edged sword in Middle Eastern geopolitics, offering strategic advantages to intervening powers while often coming at a

significant cost to regional stability and civilian populations.

BRIEF OVERVIEW OF MIDDLE-EASTERN CONFLICTS

The Origins and Development of Israeli Conflicts

In the final decades of the 19th century, a liberation movement called Zionism began calling for a Jewish state in Ottoman-ruled Palestine. An influx of Jewish immigrants and the rising tensions with local Arabs came in 1917 with the British government's Balfour Declaration endorsing a "national home for the Jewish people" in Palestine. This blow-up led to the 1936–39 Arab Revolt when Palestinian Arab nationalists launched a series of attacks against British colonial and Jewish settlement targets.

First Arab-Israeli War (1948-1949)

With the end of the Second World War, the UN Partition Plan of 1947, proposed to divide Palestine into two separate Jewish and Arab states, which turned out to create a major geopolitical shift in the Middle East. In 1948 the neighbouring Arab nation-states invaded Israel on 14 May, when the State of Israel declared independence. Although they were outnumbered, Israel's military succeeded in driving off the invasion and sweepingly expanded control beyond the borders proposed by the UN for Israel. This conflict led to the displacement of about 700,000 Palestinians, an occurrence which would later become known as the 'Nakba'. The war ended, in 1949, with truce agreements, designed to mark the 'Green Line' as a de facto border, pending a future discussion.

³ Menon, A. (2018, May 21). *Why engage in proxy war? A state's perspective*. Brookings Institution. <https://www.brookings.edu/articles/why-engage-in-proxy-war-a-states-perspective/>

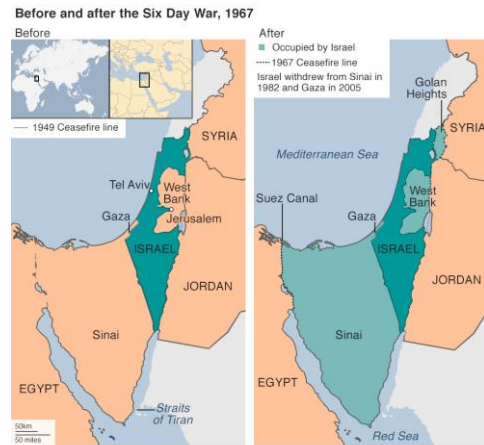
The Suez Crisis (1956)

Then Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser had nationalised the Suez Canal in July of 1956, which led to international concern. The military powers of Israel, Britain and France launched a coordinated military operation against the military powers of Egypt in October in response. Anglo-French forces took the key positions under their control which were the Canal Zone and the large, Anglo-held part of the Sinai Peninsula. Nevertheless, with the aid of international pressure especially from the United States and the Soviet Union, the withdrawal date was set by March 1957 for all forces.⁴

The Six-Day War (1967)

Tensions in the area grew to a critical point in May 1967 when Egypt mobilised the forces in Sinai and closed the Straits of Tiran to Israeli shipping.⁵ On 5 June 1967, Israel struck pre-emptively at Egyptian airfields, eliminating the Egyptian Air Force. Israeli forces led a decisive victory over Egyptian, Syrian and Jordanian combined forces over the following six days.

This conflict resulted in the Israeli occupation of the Sinai Peninsula, Gaza Strip, West Bank, East Jerusalem and Golan Heights. That territorial expansion drastically shifted the region's balance of power and posed new problems for future peace negotiations.



The Middle East before and after the Six-Day War

Source: BBC

The Yom Kippur War (1973)

On 6 October 1973, on the Jewish holy day of Yom Kippur, Israeli positions in the Sinai Peninsula and the Golan Heights were ambushed by the Egypt and the Syrian forces.⁶ The initial Arab advance caught Israel off guard, but Israeli forces managed to regroup and counter-attack after the intense fighting and significant casualties on both sides, which grabbed the attention of the United Nations. This resulted in a UN-brokered ceasefire that came into effect on 25 October 1973. The war's outcome led to a reassessment of military strategies and ultimately paved the way for the Camp David Accords which took place between Israel and Egypt in the year 1978.⁷

⁴ National Counterterrorism Center | FTOs. (n.d.). National Counterterrorism Center | FTOs. https://www.dni.gov/nctc/ftos/isis_sinai_fto.html

⁵ McManus, A. (2020, June 30). *The Egyptian Military's Terrorism Containment Campaign in North Sinai*. Carnegie Endowment for International Peace from <https://carnegieendowment.org/sada/2020/07/the-egyptian-militarys-terrorism-containment-campaign-in-north-sinai?lang=en>

⁶ The October Arab-Israeli War of 1973: What happened? (2018, October 8). Al Jazeera from <https://www.aljazeera.com/features/2018/10/8/the-october-arab-israeli-war-of-1973-what-happened>

⁷ Milestones in the History of U.S. Foreign Relations. (n.d.). Milestones in the History of U.S. Foreign Relations - Office of the Historian from <https://history.state.gov/milestones/1969-1976/arab-israeli-war-1973>

The Lebanon Conflicts

First Lebanon War (1982)

Israel's involvement in Lebanon began gaining prominence with the First Lebanon War in 1982, with the initiation of Operation Peace for Galilee by Israel. This was done in response to the attacks by Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) factions based in southern parts of Lebanon. Israeli forces swiftly advanced, reaching Beirut and forcing the evacuation and overthrowing of the PLO leadership. However, the protracted occupation of southern Lebanon led to the emergence of Hezbollah, a Shia militant group. Israel withdrew from most of Lebanon in 1985 but maintained a security zone in the south until 2000.

Second Lebanon War (2006)

The Second Lebanon War which had erupted in July 2006 following a cross-border raid done by Hezbollah.⁸ This caused a conflict that lasted 34 days and saw intense action, which included rocket attacks on northern Israel and Israeli airstrikes being carried throughout the area of Lebanon. The war ended with UN Security Council Resolution 1701, which called for a full cessation of hostilities.

Current Situation

Iran-backed Hezbollah has been trading fire with Israel since the war between Israel and the Palestinian militant group Hamas began in Gaza

in October 2023. Israel launched a ground assault inside Lebanon in September of 2024 in an attempt to stabilise the border region for its citizens who had fled the fighting. More than 2,400 people have been killed in Lebanon, most of them in the last month, according to Lebanon's health ministry, while 59 people have been killed in northern Israel and the occupied Golan Heights, according to Israeli authorities.

It is alleged that Israel's Intelligence agency, Mossad, planted small amounts of explosives inside 5,000 Taiwan-made pagers ordered by the Lebanese group Hezbollah.⁹ The operation was an unprecedented security breach for Hezbollah that saw thousands of pagers detonate across Lebanon, killing nine people and wounding nearly 3,000 others, including the group's fighters and Iran's envoy to Beirut.

Israel killed Hezbollah leader Hasan Nasrallah on 27th September 2024 in a series of airstrikes on the city of Beirut. Further, Israel claimed it also assassinated two of Hezbollah's successors in airstrikes.¹⁰

Currently, Israel continues its invasion with heavy strikes ranging from missiles, drones and even ground invasion. The UNPKO forces deployed in Lebanon under UNFIL established in Lebanon in 1978 have been caught in the cross fires of this conflict receiving damage and fatalities from both sides of the war.¹¹

⁸Israel's Lebanon War: Ariel Sharon and "operation peace for galilee." (n.d.-c). https://www.researchgate.net/publication/294246929_Israel's_Lebanon_war_Ariel_Sharon_and_'Operation_Peace_for_Galilee'

⁹Israel planted explosives in Hezbollah's Taiwan-made pagers, say sources | Reuters. (2024,September 18) <https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/israel-planted-explosives-hezbollahs-taiwan-made-pagers-say-sources-2024-09-18/>

¹⁰ Israel says it has killed slain Hezbollah leader's successors | Reuters. (2024,October 7) <https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/hezbollah-strikes-israel-gaza-war-anniversary-fears-grow-over-middle-east-2024-10-07/>

¹¹ UNIFIL. (n.d.). <https://unifil.unmissions.org/>

The Palestinian Conflicts

First Intifada

From 1987 to 1993 was the First Intifada, an extended wave of Palestinian resistance and civil disobedience against Israeli occupation in the West Bank and Gaza Strip. The uprising was marked by stone-throwing youth confronting Israeli military forces, attention that international attention brought to the Palestinian cause and the process that began the Oslo peace process was initiated.

Second Intifada

During September 2000 following the breakdown of peace negotiations, the Second Intifada, also known as the Al-Aqsa Intifada, started. During this period, violence also escalated as a result of insurgence of suicide bombings in Israeli cities and Israeli military incursions in territory occupied by Palestinians. Thousands of casualties on any side contributed to the conflict until it faded away altogether in 2005.

Beginning of Gaza Conflicts

The Gaza conflicts are a result of a series of intense military confrontations as various Israeli and Palestinian militant groups gained power post-2008 including Hamas. Although these conflicts are harbingers for the broader Israeli-Palestinian dispute, periods of escalating violence have ensued during which serious loss of life and widespread destruction have occurred on both sides. These conflicts have a historical backstory that can be traced back to Israel's unilateral disengagement from the Gaza Strip in 2005 when Israeli settlements were dismantled and almost all Israeli military forces were. It was first under the control of the Palestinian

Authority, setting the stage for the subsequent power struggles and conflicts that would follow.

Election of Hamas

In 2006, Hamas won the Palestinian elections and gained administrative control of the Gaza Strip. However, in 2007, it contested control in Gaza during a brief but violent skirmish with its rival faction, Fatah, and a large shift in power took place. This was a watershed moment in the region, closing the door on Israeli, and Egyptian blockade on the Gaza Strip, and was followed by future conflicts.

Operation Cast Lead (2008)

The first major conflict after Hamas's takeover of Gaza was Operation Cast Lead, which began on 27 December 2008 and lasted until 18 January 2009. This operation commenced with a wave of Israeli airstrikes that targeted Hamas' infrastructure and personnel, later expanding to include a ground invasion.¹² The Israeli government launched the operation in response to increased rocket fire from Gaza into southern Israel. This conflict would then last for 22-days conflict resulting in 500 Palestinians being killed in the North Gaza district, 600 in Gaza City, 150 in Central Gaza, 101 in Khan Younis, and 58 in the Rafah district. The intense fighting and high civilian casualty rate drew international criticism and calls for an immediate ceasefire, setting a pattern that would be repeated in subsequent conflicts.

Operation Pillar of Defense

Following Operation Cast Lead, a period of relative calm was shattered by Operation Pillar of Defense, which took place from 14-21 November 2012. This eight-day conflict began with Israel's targeted assassination of Ahmed Jabari, who at

¹²Adam, A. (2020, September 28). *Palestinian intifada*. Al Jazeera.

<https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2020/9/28/palestinian-intifada-20-years-later-israeli-occupation-continues>

that time was the head of Hamas's military wing. Unlike the previous operation, Pillar of Defense primarily consisted of Israeli airstrikes against militant targets in Gaza, whilst Palestinian groups launched hundreds of rockets towards Israeli population centres instead of militant activity-rich regions, which included Tel Aviv and Jerusalem for the first time. The conflict ended with a ceasefire which was brokered by Egypt, with approximately 160 Palestinian and 6 Israeli fatalities reported. This was a shorter but intense conflict that highlighted the increasing range and sophistication of Palestinian capabilities, as well as the effectiveness of Israel's Iron Dome missile defence system.

Operation Protective Edge

Operation Protective Edge was the most protracted and destructive Gaza conflict, lasting from 8 July to 26 August 2014. Abe's involvement in this 50-day stand-off was intense aerial bombardment, Israeli military ground invasion, and rockets shot from the Gaza Strip toward Israel. It left more than 2,200 Palestinians dead, many civilians, and 73 Israelis dead, most of them military. In Gaza the scale of destruction was unprecedented; entire neighbourhoods were razed, and critical infrastructure was destroyed. It expressed grave concern over the civilian death toll and damage to Gaza's fragile infrastructure. Having focused renewed attention on the need for a long-term solution to the Israeli-Palestinian dispute, this conflict's drawn-out nature and devastating effects on Gaza's civilian population pointed the way to a much more protracted new conflict.

Israel-Palestine (2021)

The tensions that sparked this 11-day confrontation were over the potential eviction of Palestinian families in East Jerusalem and clashes at the Al Aqsa Mosque compound. 256 Palestinians died and 13 Israeli military died in the fighting, which ended with an Egypt-brokered ceasefire. The volatile nature of the situation and the potential for localised incidents to quickly develop into full-scale conflict was illustrated by this round of violence.¹³



Israel's Iron Dome in Action in Tel Aviv

Source: IDF

October 7th Attacks and Consequences

The October 7 attack saw Hamas storming southern Israeli cities, after which Israel formally declared war. Hamas also launched about 2200 missiles in 20 minutes. This along with a coordinated assault using explosives and bulldozers overwhelmed the Iron Dome and other defences killing 1200 people. The attack is said to be the deadliest assault on Jews in Israel.¹⁴

A siege of the Gaza Strip was immediately put into effect, and more than a million Palestinians were told to evacuate. The United States, Israel's primary ally, pressured Israel to pull out of Gaza. Israel announced that they would withdraw from the Gaza Strip in January 2024, however, Israel

¹³ Hamas and Israel: A history of confrontation | Reuters. (2021, May 14). <https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/hamas-israel-history-confrontation-2021-05-14/>

¹⁴ Trauma of Oct 7 attack still hangs over Israel as war spreads | Reuters. (2024, October 7) <https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/trauma-oct-7-attack-still-hangs-over-israel-war-spreads-2024-10-07/>

still believes that an offensive in Gaza would be instrumental in eradicating Hamas.

As the situation stands, Gaza is low on supplies, fuel, and food as the Israel Defence Force (IDF) has been blocking aid to the region. The WHO has warned of the spread of disease and famine in the region.¹⁵

Iranian Conflicts

Modern Iranian conflicts have their origins in the mid-'90s, with the country's strategic location and many oil reserves often serving to centre Iran in regional and global power struggles.

Deposition of Mosaddegh

British and American intelligence agencies deposed the democratically elected government of Prime Minister Mohammad Mosaddegh in a coup d'état in 1953. This significant event marked the beginning of ongoing Iranian conflicts. Mosaddegh's nationalisation of Iran's successful oil industry was a key motivator behind the operation, which became known as Operation Ajax. The coup reinstated Mohammad Reza Pahlavi as Shah, who ruled with increasing authoritarianism until 1979.

Iranian Revolution (1979)

The Iranian Revolution of 1979 was due to a massive shift in the country's political landscape and its relations with the West. The Shah's rule was ended by mass protests which culminated in his overthrow and establishment of the Islamic Republic under Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini, an Iranian Islamic revolutionary, politician and religious leader who served as the first Supreme

leader of Iran from 1979 to his death in 1989. The revolution completely changed Iran's future geopolitical orientation, breaking off its long relationship with the United States and speaking with a diametrical aversion to Western influence in the region.

The newly formed Islamic Republic was openly hostile towards Israel, even referring to it as a 'Zionist Regime'. These events leading to Iran's growing influence were seen as a direct threat to Israel's security.



Source: The New York Times

Iran-Iraq War (1980)

Right after the revolution, Iran was invaded by Iraq. In September 1980, Iraq launched a major invasion of Iran, led by Saddam Hussein, who hoped to exploit the chaos following the revolution. Both sides suffered hundreds of thousands of casualties and significant economic damage in a war that lasted for eight years. Despite the initial advantages for Iraqi forces, the conflict ended in a stalemate, with borders reverting to their pre-war status. The war also marked the first use of chemical weapons by Iraq, and it significantly shaped Iran's military doctrine and future ambitions.¹⁶

¹⁵ Council on Foreign Relations. (n.d.-b). *Israeli-palestinian conflict | global conflict tracker*. Council on Foreign Relations. <https://www.cfr.org/global-conflict-tracker/conflict/israeli-palestinian-conflict>

¹⁶ Iran considered nuclear weapons during 1980s Iraq War, ex-president says | Reuters. (2015, October 29)

<https://www.reuters.com/article/world/iran-considered-nuclear-weapons-during-1980s-iraq-war-ex-president-says-idUSKCN0SNoE7/>

Nuclear Ambitions

The beginning of Iran's nuclear program under Shah with the support of the US became one of the biggest sources of tensions not only in the Middle East but internationally. The series of UN Security Council resolutions and economic sanctions that were imposed on Iran over the amicable dimensions of the programme caused concerns about its military face. The conflict peaked early in the 2010s with speculation of possible Israeli or US military action.

After lengthy negotiations, Iran and the P5+1 countries (China, France, Germany, Russia, United Kingdom, United States) finally concluded the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), otherwise known as the Iran nuclear deal in 2015. In exchange for the relief in sanctions, Iran was placed under limits on its nuclear activities by this agreement. But the deal unravelled in 2018 when the US unilaterally ditched it and reimposed sanctions, sucking Iran into a growing standoff and its gradual disengagement from JCPOA commitments.



The JCPOA Meeting
Source: Britannica

Iran has been a leading player in several regional conflicts since the 1979 revolution, exercising what influence it has through support for non-state actors in neighbouring countries. Since the 1980s Tehran has offered substantial backing to Hezbollah in Lebanon helping make it a force in Lebanese politics.

Beginning in 2011, the Syrian Civil War became a key supporter of the Assad regime which Iran

offered through the means of military advisers, combat troops and economic aid.

Proxies of Iran

Iran has been accused of supporting Houthi rebels in the ongoing Yemeni Civil War, although the extent of this support is disputed among international observers. This conflict is driven by sectarian differences, primarily between Sunni Saudi Arabia and Shia Iran, as well as competing regional aspirations and differing alliances with Western powers. The repercussions of this struggle have been felt in Yemen, Syria, and Lebanon.

Iran continues to face significant challenges in its relations with the West and its regional rivals. Efforts to revive the JCPOA show varying levels of progress, while tensions with the United States remain high, particularly in the Persian Gulf. Iran's ballistic missile programme and its support for regional non-state actors continue to be flashpoints with neighbouring countries and the international community.

Iran-Israel Conflict and Current Situation

Iran and Israel have been at odds ever since the Islamic Revolution. Disputes between both parties regarding Iran's nuclear program fuelled the already existing hatred and the Stuxnet cyber attacks on Iran's nuclear centrifuges fuelled the ever-rising tension. While Iran has provided military and financial support to these proxy groups, Israel has conducted several airstrikes targeting Iranian assets and proxies in Syria, Iraq and Lebanon. Israel specifically has displayed displeasure upon Iran's support to Hamas in Gaza which is claimed by Israel to be a part of its territory.

On 1 October 2024, Iran fired missile offences that included ICBMs on Tel Aviv, killing 2 civilians. The strike was carried out in response to the killing of the Hezbollah chief, Hassan Nasrallah and the land invasion of Lebanon by Israeli forces. A

gunman in Tel Aviv also killed 6 before the air raid started.¹⁷ Iran's mission at the United Nations said in a statement that Iran carried out a "legal, rational, and legitimate response to the terrorist acts of the Zionist regime." The statement added that "should the Zionist regime dare to respond or commit further acts of malevolence, a subsequent and crushing response will ensue." Both parties were at odds at the UN General Assembly and vowed retaliation.

Iraqi Conflicts

The Iran-Iraq War (1980–88)

It was the longest and most deadly conventional conflict in the 20th century. The Iraqi forces led by Saddam Hussein initiated the war. Starting from Iraq's invasion of Iran, it then took advantage of the chaos following the Iranian Revolution in the surrounding region. These conflicts, spanning several decades, have been characterised by internal strife, external intervention by powers, and complex sectarian dynamics, leaving an indelible mark on Iraqi society and international relations.¹⁸

International powers, which included the United States, the Soviet Union, and various European nations, played a significant role in supplying arms to both sides, which caused further fueling of the conflict.

An estimated 1 million casualties on both sides marked the end of the war and both countries accepted UN Resolution 598, calling for an

immediate ceasefire. The protracted conflict had grave economic consequences on both nations installing a basis for instability in the region later.

Saddam Hussein and Kuwait Conflict

In 1990, Saddam Hussein of Iraq invaded and annexed Kuwait on 2nd August 1990. That war became known as the Gulf War. International condemnation followed this act of aggression and a US-led coalition carrying out a United Nations-approved liberation of Kuwait from Iraqi forces was formed.



Saddam Hussein
Source: BBC

Operation Desert Storm began on 17 January 1991, with an intensive aerial and naval bombardment, and a ground offensive.¹⁹ The conflict ended quickly with Kuwait liberated and Iraqi forces retreating by 28 February 1991. The aftermath was strict economic sanctions on Iraq, imposed by the UN and no-fly zones in the north and south of Iraq to protect Kurdish and Shia communities. While it was meant to suppress Hussein's regime, the sanctions had extremely

¹⁷ Israel vows response to Iran missile attack as fears of conflict escalation rise | Reuters. (2024, September 30) <https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/israeli-military-has-begun-limited-raids-against-hezbollah-targets-border-area-2024-09-30/>

¹⁸ *Iran-Iraq War | Causes, Summary, Casualties, & Facts*. (2024, September 15). Britannica. from <https://www.britannica.com/event/Iran-Iraq-War>

¹⁹ *Nation observes anniversary of operation desert storm*. U.S. Department of Defense. (n.d.). <https://www.defense.gov/News/News-Stories/Article/Article/2879147/nation-observes-anniversary-of-operation-desert-storm/>

human consequences for the people of Iraq in the years that followed.²⁰

Iraq War (2003)

One of the most significant moments in Iraq's history was the 2003 Iraq War. A coalition led by the US invaded Iraq in response to allegations of the production of weapons of mass destruction and ties to terrorism. The military campaign unfolded rapidly, with Baghdad falling on 9 April 2003, leading to the swift collapse of Saddam Hussein's government shortly thereafter.



US Soldiers in Iraq
Source: DW

The aftermath of the invasion proved even more challenging and chaotic. It fuelled an insurgency against coalition forces, particularly after the controversial disbandment of the Iraqi army and the de-Baathification process, which led to widespread unemployment and resentment among the population. While Saddam Hussein had long suppressed sectarian tensions, the fall of his regime triggered open conflict between Sunni and Shia groups in Baghdad. The collapse of the Ba'athist regime created a power vacuum that allowed Al-Qaeda in Iraq to resurface, eventually evolving into ISIS, a group that exploited the chaos in both Iraq and Syria.

Iraq faced the daunting task of rebuilding its government and infrastructure while grappling

with a growing insurgency, all amidst sanctions and deteriorating relations with major powers following the 2003 invasion. Although the US officially ended combat operations in 2011, many military personnel remained for training and advising Iraqi forces, and violence persisted throughout the country.

In 2014, a new and formidable threat emerged when ISIS seized large territories in Iraq and parts of Syria. This prompted various Iraqi factions to fight against ISIS, leading to renewed international military involvement, including US military support for Iraqi forces and Kurdish Peshmerga fighters, alongside airstrikes from a US-led coalition. Iraq declared victory over ISIS in December 2017, achieving success in terms of territorial control. However, the conflict took a heavy toll on Iraqi civilians and infrastructure, displacing millions and leaving many cities in ruins, while the ideology and remnants of ISIS continue to pose a threat in the region.

Syrian Conflicts

Post-Independence Period (post 1946–70)

Though Syria already had a history of political instability thanks to multiple coups d'état even before its independence from France in 1946, postwar innocence was lost. It was a period of turbulence that ended in 1970 when Hafez al-Assad came to power and presided over 30 years of authoritarian rule. Assad's rule had been marked by a strong centralised state, suppression of opposition and a foreign policy that was often at odds with Western interests.

Following Hafez al-Assad's death in 2000, his son Bashar al-Assad assumed the presidency, initially

²⁰ U.S. Department of State. (n.d.-c). *Effect of Sanctions on the Iranian State*. U.S. Department of State.
<https://www.state.gov/iran-sanctions/>

promising reforms but then later largely continuing his father's authoritarian policies.²¹

Syrian Civil War

After the Arab Spring, the cracks in the al-Assad regime were beginning to show. Syria in 2011 was slowly heading towards a state of instability as economic and political reform had been slow. Syrian President al-Assad hoped his nation would be spared from the uprisings seen in other countries like Egypt and Tunisia because of Syria's anti-US stance. Syria had a Sunni majority population, whereas the ruling members belonged to the Alawite minority. This sectarian divide only hardened as the conflict progressed. Assad claimed the opposition was Sunni extremists and that they had ties to Al-Qaeda. Protests began relatively peacefully, however, the government cracked down on the protests with extreme force. The EU, the US, and the rest of the Arab League called for the abdication of the Assad regime and soon introduced sanctions. Iran and Russia, allies of Syria continued their support to the regime.

The protests soon turned violent, as defectors from the Syrian army soon formed the Free Syrian Army or the FSA.²² The anti-Assad regime received arms from Turkey, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and eventually the US, and the regime received arms from Iran and Hezbollah from Lebanon.

In 2013, other Islamist organisations began to take centre stage. Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, the leader of Al-Qaeda in Iraq announced that he would combine the Iraqi and Syrian forces under ISIL.

The conflict was focused on the usage of chemical weapons. In Ghouta (2013) and, most notably, Khan Sheikhoun (2017), multiple alleged uses of chemical weapons have elicited international condemnation and limited Western attacks on government targets.²³

Turkey, Lebanon and Jordan were feeling the brunt of the human catastrophe because of the influx of millions of Syrian refugees.

The Syrian conflict had turned into a bargaining ground between rival regional and global powers and one that had heightened tensions between Iran and Saudi Arabia, Russia and the West.

Today, the Syrian conflict continues to remain unsettled even as the combatants has eased off in much of the fighting. For much of the country, Assad's government, backed by Russia and Iran, had regained control.



Source: AP

Russia began to take an active role in the conflict in 2013, by sending troops and equipment to the Syrian government.

Russia and Turkey have been trying to enact buffer zones between government and rebel forces.

²¹ Al Jazeera. (2018, April 14). *Syria's war explained from the beginning*.
<https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2018/4/14/syrias-war-explained-from-the-beginning>

²² Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (2024, October 18). *Syrian Civil War*. Encyclopædia Britannica.
<https://www.britannica.com/place/Syria/Uprising-and-civil-war#ref127068>

²³ Council on Foreign Relations. (n.d.). *Conflict in syria | global conflict tracker*. Council on Foreign Relations.
<https://www.cfr.org/global-conflict-tracker/conflict/conflict-syria>

While much of Turkey still lies beyond the reach of the Syrian Kurds, it is patrolled by Turkish forces. There's a military presence in northern Syria chiefly to prevent Kurdish forces from extending control north. An ostensibly small US military presence in eastern Syria is maintained there, trying to stymie an IS resurgence and keep the Iranians at bay.²⁴

However, rebuilding Syria's infrastructure, let alone its societal divides, is a big job. Western sanctions also further complicate things, as they continue to restrict the Syrian economy and reconstruction. Together these factors make the continuing complexity of the situation in Syria, as it strives to get to stability and recovery.

Black September

Tensions between the Jordanian government and Palestinian factions had heightened after an unsuccessful assassination attempt on King Hussein's life on 1 September 1970. Things escalated when four airliners were hijacked by a PLO faction, the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP), on 6 September 1970. Three of the aircraft were forced to land anyway at Dawson's Field, a remote Jordanian airstrip.

To these provocations, King Hussein of Jordan responded by imposing martial law on 16 September 1970. Most of its soldiers were loyal Bedouin troops of the Jordanian army who launched a campaign to retake the country. Intense fighting broke out in Amman and other cities and between Jordanian forces and Palestinian militants. The conflict was particularly vicious in Palestinian refugee camps.²⁵

When Syria intervened in the crisis on 18 September 1970, sending tanks into northern

Jordan, the crisis became international. However Syrian forces had to pull back, in response to a mixture of Jordanian resistance and the danger of Israeli and US intervention. It took ten days of heavy combat before the Arab nations managed to broker a ceasefire on 27 September 1970. However, sporadic clashes continued until July 1971, with the source of the conflict deep-rooted.

The Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) was forced out of Jordan along with many Palestinian militant groups and leading to a wide ripple effect that contributed to the Lebanese Civil War.

Through this conflict, King Hussein strengthened his power and brought Jordan closer to Western powers. It also was radicalising, as Palestinian groups were expelled from Jordan, resulting in the birth of the Black September Organisation, the organisation that perpetrated many notorious terrorist attacks, including the unfortunate Munich Olympics massacre of 1972.

The conflict's aftermath also strained Jordan's relations with other Arab states, particularly Syria and Egypt, who chose to support the Palestinian cause over Jordan's interests. This change in alliances carried with it a major effect on the region's political terrain and exacerbated the difference between peace and stability in the Middle East. Changes that took place during Black September forced the PLO to take a more diplomatic approach towards Palestinian statehood. Yet this change in tactics would have lengthening implications for PLO's future strategies as well as PLO engagements with the international community.

In addition, the events of Black September highlighted the complexities and divisions between the Arabs and the difficulties of

²⁴ Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (n.d.). *Syrian Civil War*. Encyclopædia Britannica.
<https://www.britannica.com/event/Syrian-Civil-War>

²⁵ Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (2024b, October 21). *Jordan and King Hussein*. Encyclopædia Britannica.
<https://www.britannica.com/place/Jordan/Jordan-under-King-Hussein>

maintaining pan-Arab unity against Israel. It cast a pall on efforts to forge a consistent line of Arab states against Israel and underscored the necessity of more flexible and comprehensive approaches to achieve regional consensus and peace.²⁶

The rise of extremist organisations has also contributed to political instability and challenges to democratic governance.²⁷ Many such organisations have emerged in response to perceived injustice, corruption, and lack of representation. A significant example is the Arab Spring, a wave of protests and uprisings that began in 2010. In countries like Egypt, Syria, and Yemen, initially peaceful protests escalated into violent conflicts, creating openings that extremist groups sought to exploit amid the ensuing chaos.

Yemeni Civil War

The Houthi movement has its roots in Zaydi society, which is a minor sect in the Shia community and is based in Northern Yemen. It was founded by the politician and Zaydi activist Hussein Badr al-Din al-Houthi. Tensions between the Houthis and the Yemeni government increased after the 2003 US Invasion of Iraq, as President Ali Abdullah Saleh's

Hussein al-Houthi used the US invasion to gain support within the Zaydi community and engineered chants such as "Death to America". This further escalated situations between President Saleh's regime and Hussein al-Houthi, causing the former to crack down on the movement. Hussein was later killed by Yemeni

armed forces, which further escalated tensions between the Yemeni government and the rebels.

The Arab Spring saw rebellions rise not only in Northern Africa but also in the Middle East. In the spirit of the Arab awakening, the Yemeni demanded that Saleh step down. Saleh eventually stepped down and was replaced by the vice president, Abd Rabbuh Mansur Hadi.

In July 2014, the Houthis took advantage of political weaknesses in Hadi's government and captured Yemen's capital city Sana'a.²⁸ Saudi Arabia, fearing that a Houthi Yemen would become an Iranian proxy, aimed to restore the original government and was backed by the United States, United Kingdom and France. Coalition forces landed in Aden and pushed back the Houthis from South Yemen, however, they failed to drive them out of Sana'a or Northern Yemen. Despite fierce fighting, both sides have been locked in a stalemate. Fighting escalated in 2023 when the Houthis targeted the United Arab Emirates and Saudi oil installations.²⁹

Iran has been suspected of supplying arms to the Houthi rebels, however, Iran denies these claims.

The Houthi slogan calls for the destruction of the American and Israeli state, and a curse upon the Jewish people. In response to the Israel-Gaza conflict, the Houthis fired missiles towards Israel, most of which were intercepted. The Houthis then started to target naval vessels that were linked with Israel or headed for Israeli ports, however many vessels that were attacked had no association with Israel. American and British naval vessels have also been attacked in response

²⁶ Fifty years after "Black september" in Jordan. (n.d.-a). <https://www.cia.gov/resources/csi/static/Black-September-Jordan.pdf>

²⁷ Byman, D. (2011, June 15). *The rise of the PLO and the birth of international terrorism (1956–1970s)*. OUP Academic. <https://academic.oup.com/book/9047/chapter-abstract/155557044?redirectedFrom=fulltext>

²⁸ Yemen Crisis explained. (n.d.-c). <https://www.unrefugees.org/news/yemen-crisis-explained/>

²⁹ Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (n.d.-b). *Yemeni Civil War*. Encyclopædia Britannica. <https://www.britannica.com/event/Yemeni-Civil-War>

to what the rebels called “American-British Aggression”. These attacks affected trade and jeopardised global shipping that passed through the region. In response to this, the USA and the UK started to carry out airstrikes in Houthi Yemen, to protect their trade interests.

Iran-Saudi Proxy Conflict

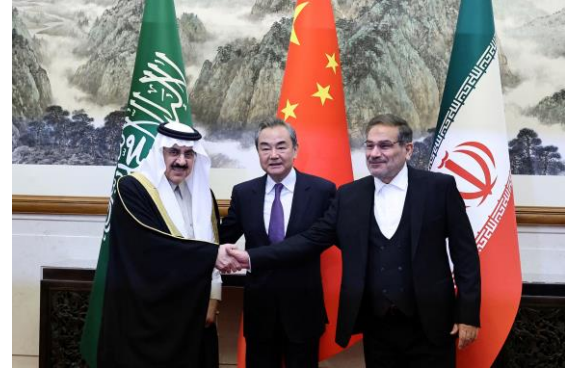
Over the past decade, the struggle between Iran and Saudi Arabia for dominance in the Middle East has worked its way into nearly every regional issue, fracturing international alliances and sustaining wars across the region. The conflict stems from several issues—primarily regional, ethnic and economic conflicts. Both countries are Muslim-majority, but Shia Islamism is predominantly followed in Iran, unlike Saudi Arabia which mainly follows Sunni Islamism. This has led to both nations wanting to have a dominant grasp over the Muslim world.³⁰

This rivalry can be dated back to 1924. Under Ibn Saud, present-day Saudi Arabia was unified after years of conflict. Yet, celebrations were short-lived as another power rose across the Persian Gulf. A year later, Reza Khan established the Pahlavi dynasty in Persia, becoming the Shah. Their relationship started on a bitter note. In 1925, a controversy erupted when Saudi Arabia partially destroyed a revered Shiite site, prompting Persia to protest. This disagreement led to a ban on Persian pilgrims in the following years.

The 1979 Iranian Revolution, known as both the Iranian Revolution and the Islamic Revolution, brought an end to the over 2,500-year-old Pahlavi dynasty and replaced it with the Islamic Republic of Iran. Iran's transformation into a Shiite theocracy challenged Saudi Arabia's title as

the representative of the Sunni world causing existing sectarian tensions to amplify, fuelling suspicion between the two countries.

Normalization of Arab-Israeli relations



Wang Yi, a member of the Political Bureau of the Communist Party of China (CPC) Central Committee and director of the Office of the Central Foreign Affairs Commission, Ali Shamkhani, the secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, and Minister of State and national security adviser of Saudi Arabia Musaad bin Mohammed Al Aiban pose for pictures during a meeting in Beijing, China March 10, 2023

Source: Reuters

In the latter half of 2020, the UAE, Morocco, Sudan and to an extent, Bahrain, have agreed to recognize the state of Israel. A move supported by the Trump administration. Palestine sees the normalization of relations between these countries as a stab in the back. Furthermore, on 10th March, the People's Republic of China brokered a deal between Iran and Saudi Arabia, resuming diplomatic relations after 7 years of tensions between the two nations. The two nations engaged in bilateral agreements as well as opened embassies in Tehran and Riyadh, after the trilateral agreement with China.³¹

³⁰ War of words: Saudi Arabia v Iran. European Union Institute for Security Studies. (2019, September 23).

<https://www.iss.europa.eu/content/war-words-saudi-arabia-v-iran>

³¹ Al Jazeera. (2023, August 3). Israel, UAE and Bahrain sign US-brokered normalisation deals. <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2020/9/15/israel-uae-and-bahrain-sign-us-brokered-normalisation-deals>

The Kurdish Question

Kurdistan is a geographic region that spans eastern Turkey, northern Iraq and western Iran, as well as some parts of Armenia and Syria. This area has been home to the Kurdish people and had been under Kurdish rule in the 10th, 11th and 12th centuries.³² However, the land eventually came to be governed by the Ottoman Empire. After the Treaty of Sevres in 1920, the Kurds were given considerable autonomy, however, this treaty was never ratified because of the Turkish War of Independence. Therefore the Kurdish question remained a matter of contention.³³ During the Iran-Iraq war in the 1980s, the Iranians supported the Kurdish guerillas, to distract the Iraqis from the Iranian front. This led to several Kurds joining Iranian units. The rebellion was put down, however the crackdown was harsh and caused chemical attacks, concentration camps and mass executions. This event is known as the Anfal Campaign or the Kurdish genocide. Because of events such as the Gulf War and the Iraqi civil war, the Kurdish movement has gained traction as Kurdish fighters become leading figures in ISIL and there were discussions concerning Kurdish independence. Referendums for independence were held in Iraq's Kurdish autonomous region, which passed overwhelmingly. However, dreams of liberty were short-lived as Iraqi and Turkish military interventions subdued local Kurdish forces.

The UNPKO forces deployed in Lebanon under UNFIL established in Lebanon in 1978, have been caught in the cross fires of this conflict receiving

damage and even fatalities from both sides of the war.³⁴

South Africa's Case Against Israel

On 29 December 2023, the Republic of South Africa initiated legal proceedings against the state of Israel at the International Court of Justice. This accused Israel of committing genocide against Palestine in the Gaza Strip.

The case emphasized the actions of the Israeli nation and drew attention to the legal definition of genocide and accusing them of violating several international laws which also included a breach of its obligations under the 1948 Genocide Convention in its crackdown against Hamas.³⁵ This case also accuses Hamas of targeting and attacking Israeli civilians with weaponry such as rockets and missiles in recent years.

Israel's spokesperson denied all plausibility of intention and harm to non-combatants and even called out South Africa as complicit alongside Hamas.

Hamas denies the use of the population of Gaza as a human shield.

Both parties face accusations of violating international humanitarian law, especially regarding the proportionality and the need to use their military actions.

After a session of voting, The International Court of Justice expressed great concern about Israel's military offensive in Rafah, they also stated that

³²Council on Foreign Relations. (n.d.-b). *Timeline: The Kurds' quest for independence*. Council on Foreign Relations. <https://www.cfr.org/timeline/kurds-long-struggle-statelessness>

³³Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (2024a, September 27). *Kurdistan*. Encyclopædia Britannica. <https://www.britannica.com/place/Kurdistan>

³⁴UNIFIL. (n.d.). <https://unifil.unmissions.org/>

³⁵Israel to appear before ICJ to counter South Africa's Gaza Case | Reuters. (2024, January 2). <https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/israel-says-it-will-appear-before-icj-counter-south-africas-gaza-case-2024-01-02/>

Israel had shown lacklustre efforts to safeguard civilians especially those that have been displaced from the regions surrounding Rafah. The court also ruled: "a change in the situation within the meaning of Article 76 of the Rules of Court".

The court also was in the view that provisional measures were indicated in its order on 28 March 2024.

On 5 April 2024, the court set the schedule for comprehensive submissions of legal opinions by South Africa and Israel. The time limit for the South African memorial was set to be 28 October 2024 and for the Israeli response 28 July 2025.

In May prosecutors asked for warrants for Netanyahu and Gallant, saying there were reasonable grounds that the men committed war crimes and crimes against humanity by systematically depriving civilians in Gaza of "objects indispensable to human survival" including food, water, medicine and energy.³⁶

There is no set deadline for judges to decide on the warrants. Pre-trial judges often take months to decide on such requests. Dozens of countries have filed submissions in the high-profile case. Israel contested the request on Sept. 20. Any potential ICC trial regarding the Israel-Hamas conflict is likely years away.

CAUSES OF CONFLICTS IN THE MIDDLE EAST

Territorial Disputes and Resource Struggles

Territorial disputes and competition for resources are one of the main causes of conflicts in the Middle East. Abundant natural resources like oil and gas have long been a cause for contention and conflict in the region. The

artificial states have been created across borders drawn arbitrarily by colonial powers ignoring ethnic, religious or tribal affiliation, and dividing historical territories. As a result of this, there have been ongoing disputes regarding land, water and other vital resources.

The conflict between Israel and its Arab neighbours over the West Bank, Gaza and the Golan Heights is a perfect example. A protracted conflict in which the state of Israel was established in 1948 and hundreds of thousands of Palestinians displaced, continues to shape the region's politics and security dynamics.

Ethnic and Religious Diversity

The Middle East is a vast region of great ethnic, religious and sectarian diversity from Arabs, Kurds, Jews, Christians and different Muslim sects to name a few. Often characterised by the interplay between these disparate groups as power struggles, discrimination, and self-determination, many conflicts have followed.

For instance, the Kurdish people have long sought to govern themselves, spreading across Iraq, Syria, Turkey and Iran, and regularly clashing with the governments of the lands they occupy. Suppression of Kurdish aspirations as well as the denial of importance given to their cultural and political rights had been a source of tension and conflict in the region.

Political Instability and Lack of Democratic Governance

The conflicts in the region have been overwhelmingly a function of political instability and the lack of democratic governance. Middle Eastern countries have been run by authoritarian leaders who have centred their power and interests over the welfare of their citizens. It has

³⁶What war crimes are Israel and Hamas accused of one year after Oct 7 attack? | Reuters. (2024, October 1). <https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/what-war-crimes-are-israel-hamas-accused-one-year-2024-10-01/>

spawned enormous corruption, grew economic inequality, and suffocated political dissent. This has made the perfect climate for social unrest and the growth of extremist groups.

In 2011, the Arab Spring saw a deeper shift in the Middle Eastern system of power, exposing the weaknesses of authoritarian entrenched governance in Tunisia, Egypt, Libya, and Syria. In reaction to these developments, Iran, Syria, and Hezbollah forged an "axis of resistance" against the U.S.-led regional order. At the same time, pulling the United States out, Russia began to demonstrate its support of Assad in Syria, creating new regional alliances. Security challenges with Israel, Saudi Arabia, and Iran raised tensions to a boiling point.

These tensions can be managed and diffused with international dialogue and by initiatives in neutral state-led mediation and diplomacy.³⁷

External Powers and Geopolitical Interests

Conflicts in the Middle East are said to be exacerbated by the involvement of external powers and the desire for geopolitical interests. The focus of global powers with the region's strategic importance and the armful of energy resources.

These powers have traditionally complicated and blocked resolutions of conflicts in the past through direct or indirect supply and support of arms and other types of assistance done by major powers.

However, the ongoing proxy wars that were played out during the conflicts between Saudi Arabia and Iran and others add to the region's

instability. A prolonged conflict, and the suffering of civilians, have often resulted from the alignment of external powers with some factions and the pursuit of their geopolitical agenda.

ACTIVE NON-STATE ACTORS

Hamas

Hamas is a Palestinian militant Islamist organisation, based in the Gaza Strip and the West Bank. Their objective is to establish an Islamic State in historical Palestine.³⁸ The organization was founded by activists in the Muslim Brotherhood dissatisfied with the PLO's secular stance on Palestine and actively called for Jihad in the occupied territories. Hamas believes that an Islamic homeland cannot be surrendered to non-Muslims, and is known to conduct attacks on civilians.³⁹ The US designated Hamas as a terrorist organization in 1997, along with the EU also making the same classification in 2003. Hamas is expected to be led by the ruling committee post the death of Yahya Sinwar until their next elections.

ISIS/ISIL

Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant (ISIL) is a transnational Sunni terrorist organization, whose main objective is to solidify the domain of Islam and expand its influence through strict implementation of the Sharia and regain territory previously ruled by the Caliphate.

The organisation began in Al-Raqqah and expanded its influence outwards into Syria and Iraq, proclaiming the liberation of captured

³⁷ Fueling middle east conflicts—or dousing the Flames - Carnegie Endowment for International Peace | Carnegie Endowment for International peace. (n.d.-b). <https://carnegieendowment.org/research/2018/10/fueling-middle-east-conflictsor-dousing-the-flames>

³⁸ Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (2024c, October 19). *Hamas*. Encyclopædia Britannica. <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Hamas>

³⁹ UN independent experts 'unequivocally condemn' violence against civilians in Israel, Gaza. (2023, October 19). UN News. <https://news.un.org/en/story/2023/10/1142572>

lands. They soon after declared the establishment of the Caliphate with Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi as the Caliph. They are based in Syria and Iraq and are led by Abu Hafs al-Hashimi al-Qurashi⁴⁰

Al-Qaeda

Al-Qaeda is an Islamist organisation founded by Osama Bin Laden after the 9/11 attacks. It was originally founded as a logistics network during the Soviet-Afghan War (1979-1989). The organisation was based in Afghanistan under Taliban patronage and conducted several jihads in the United States. The 2001 invasion of Afghanistan put a strain on Al-Qaeda as communications and financial linkages were compromised, however, several autonomous and independent groups subscribed to Al-Qaeda's ideology during this period. The number of Al-Qaeda attacks conducted significantly increased after this. Osama Bin Laden was killed in 2011, after which his long-serving deputy Ayman al-Zawahiri became leader.

Houthis

The Houthis are an Islamist fundamentalist group based in Northern Yemen, who belong to the Zaydi, a small sect of Shia Islam. Although this group wasn't militarised at first, crackdowns from the Yemeni government, as well as funding from Iran radicalised the organization.⁴¹ The movement was founded by Hussein Badr al-Din al-Houthi, who was killed by Yemeni forces. Further escalations led to the Yemeni civil war, and the Houthi capture of Sanaa in 2017. The Houthis were in conflict with the Saudi-led coalition, who were supplying humanitarian and military aid to the Yemeni government. The Houthis on the other hand, are suspected of

getting arms from Iran. The Houthis also have a strong anti-Israel stance and launched missiles and drones towards Israel and passing by ships after the October 7th attacks. This prompted the US and the UK to launch strikes of their own. The organization is now led by Abdul-Malik al-Houthi.

FSA

The FSA or Free Syrian Army is the military wing of the Syrian revolution. Their goal is to overthrow the Assad regime. Though they are not a centralized organization, the FSA originally fought for the SNC or Syrian National Council, however, the SNC could not form a legitimate opposition and the FSA slowly drifted to Islamism. The FSA consists mainly of Syrian Army defectors and is led by Riad Mousa al-Asaad.

Hezbollah

Hezbollah is a Shi'ite Lebanese organization that was founded in 1982. The organization is closely tied to Iran and is considered to be one of the most heavily armed militias in the world. The organization was founded to force Israel out of Lebanon and establish an Islamic Republic.

The end of the Lebanese civil war was enforced by the Syrians, and Hezbollah was one of the few groups that remained armed. As the nation split into anti and pro-Syrian camps, Hezbollah aligned itself with the pro-Syrian camp. The assassination of Rafic al-Hairiri Desparked popular backlash leading to Syrian withdrawal from Lebanon. This led to Hezbollah organizing a massive rally in support of Syria. Hezbollah also fought a guerilla war in southern Lebanon, which escalated in 2006. However, Lebanon was the only Arab militia that fought the IDF to a

⁴⁰ Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (2024e, October 22). *Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant*. Encyclopædia Britannica. <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Islamic-State-in-Iraq-and-the-Levant>

⁴¹ Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (2024b, October 17). *Houthi movement*. Encyclopædia Britannica. <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Houthi-movement>

standstill, which led to popularity. The organization used this opportunity to topple the Lebanese government and gain more cabinet seats.



Hezbollah Fighters
Source: France 24

In 2016, Michel Aoun, a Hezbollah ally was elected president and in 2018, Hezbollah became the most dominant party. Although organization members didn't get access to cabinet seats, the organization had significant influence over them. However, the new cabinet struggled to effectively lead the nation, resulting in massive demonstrations across the country that called for the resignation of the government. Although the resignation did come, the new government faced several challenges including the COVID-19 pandemic, hyperinflation and the Beirut explosion. This led to the resignation of the new government. The organization lost their dominance in Lebanese politics in 2022.⁴²

In 2023, Hezbollah and the IDF faced off in the Golan Heights, an area contested by Israel and Lebanon. As Israel turned its attention

northwards, Israel conducted several targeted strikes and exploded thousands of pagers and walkie-talkies which led to several casualties. Hezbollah sent a missile aiming for Tel Aviv however this was intercepted by Israel's Iron Dome. On September 27th, the Israeli air force dropped 80 bombs on south Beirut, which led to Hezbollah chief Nasrallah's death. Israel conducted a land invasion of southern Lebanon on the first of October 2024 with the help of special forces and followed it through 70 small covert raids.^{43 44}

Muslim Brotherhood

The Muslim Brotherhood is a political organization formed in 1928 whose agenda consists of referring to the Quran as guidelines for a healthy Islamic society to function. The Brotherhood was based in Egypt and organized protests against the government during the Second World War.⁴⁵ The group soon raised a militia that conducted bombings and assassinations for the brotherhood. The revolutionary regime established in 1952 by Abdul Gamal Nasser forced the Brotherhood to go underground. After the Brotherhood's attempted assassination of Nasser, the group was forcibly suppressed. The group saw a renaissance during the 1980s with an increase in religious activities in Islamic countries. This time, however, the group had an anti-West rhetoric. The group re-emerged in Syria, Egypt and Jordan. A brotherhood uprising in Syria was brutally put down by Hafiz al-Assad, whereas the

⁴² Council on Foreign Relations. (n.d.-c). *What is Hezbollah?*. Council on Foreign Relations.
<https://www.cfr.org/background/what-hezbollah>

⁴³ Lebanese troops pull back from border as Israeli ground invasion looms | Reuters. (2024, September 29) <https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/apartment-building-beirut-hit-israel-widens-air-campaign-2024-09-29/>

⁴⁴ Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (2024e, October 20). *Hezbollah*. Encyclopædia Britannica.
<https://www.britannica.com/topic/Hezbollah>

⁴⁵ Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. (2024b, September 27). *Muslim Brotherhood*. Encyclopædia Britannica.
<https://www.britannica.com/topic/Muslim-Brotherhood>

Brotherhood in Egypt and Jordan could compete politically.

In Egypt, a youth protest movement led to the resignation of Egyptian President Hosni Mubarak. This allowed the Muslim Brotherhood open access to Egyptian elections which they won handily. Khairat al-Shater was nominated as president however he was disqualified, and was replaced by Mohammed Morsi. However, Morsi's administration faced heavy opposition in the form of mass protests in 2013, which prompted the military to intervene. The military ousted Morsi from power, and initiated a crackdown on the Muslim Brotherhood, leading to mass trials and arrests.⁴⁶

RESOLUTIONS AND PAST INTERNATIONAL ACTIONS

Resolutions

Resolution 242 (1967)

It was passed for the withdrawal by Israel from occupied territories and acknowledged the right of every people to live in peace within secure borders, passed on November 22, 1967, after the Six-Day War.

Resolution 338 (1973)

Adopted throughout the Yom Kippur War on October 22, 1973, it required an immediate ceasefire and a consideration for Resolution 242. It helped spur the conflict and promoted negotiations.

Resolution 425 (1978)

Enacted on March 19, 1978, shortly after Israel invaded southern Lebanon, the resolution which it is named after, called for Israel's withdrawal, as

well as the establishment of the UN peacekeeping force UNIFIL. The goal was to bring peace to southern Lebanon.

Resolution 446 (1979)

It, adopted March 22, 1979, declares Israeli settlements in the occupied territory as being illegal under international law, and orders Israel to adhere to the Fourth Geneva Convention. It helped to bring international opposition to Israeli settlement activities.

Resolution 497 (1981)

It was passed on December 17, 1981, and declared Israel's annexation of the Golan Heights null and void, calling on Israel to rescind this decision. It was a reinforcement of the view that the Golan Heights is occupied territory.

Resolution 598 (1987)

It was passed on July 20, 1987, during the Iran–Iraq War, in which it demanded a ceasefire and withdrawal of forces to recognised borders. Within it, it laid the groundwork for ending the war, but that took time.

Resolution 660 (1990)

Adopted on August 2, 1990, after Iraq invaded Kuwait, it condemned the invasion and demanded Iraq's withdrawal. That established the stage for the Gulf War and international military intervention.

Resolution 661 (1990)

Imposed after Iraq invaded Kuwait on August 6, 1990, it passed economic sanctions on Iraq. Its purpose was to force Iraq to withdraw without armed intervention.

⁴⁶ United Nations. (n.d.). *United Nations Digital Library System*. United Nations. <https://digitallibrary.un.org/?ln=en>

Resolution 687 (1991)

Organised on 3 April 1991, the Gulf War ceasefire document stipulated the terms of the ceasefire (withdrawal of Iraq from Kuwait, destruction of WMDs), adopted on that day. It also set reparations and monitoring.

Resolution 1441 (2002)

On November 8, 2002, it handed Iraq one last opportunity to fulfil disarmament obligations and called for transparency concerning its WMD programmes. But it became the basis for the 2003 Iraq invasion when its authorization for force was debated.

Resolution 1701 (2006)

It passed on August 11, 2006, following the Lebanon War, which imposed a ceasefire on Israel and Hezbollah, and gave impetus to the UN peacekeeping force in Lebanon. It aimed to stabilise the region after the war. The area between the Blue Line and Litani River was occupied by peacekeepers and Hezbollah was constrained to stay in Lebanon above the river.

Resolution 2118 (2013)

The resolution, passed on September 27, 2013, called for Syria's destruction of its chemical weapons stockpile, under the supervision of its inspectors. Solving chemical weapon use in Syria's war was critical.

Resolution 2254 (2015)

On December 18, 2015, it was passed in response to the Syrian Civil War and it endorsed a roadmap of peace, including a ceasefire and negotiations between the government and those opposed to it. Its goal was to design tools to facilitate resolution of the conflict.

Resolution 2286 (2016)

It condemned attacks on medical personnel and facilities in such conflict zones and called for accountability, adopted on May 3, 2016. The dire healthcare situation in war-torn Syria was highlighted.

Resolution 2334 (2016)

It was adopted on December 23, 2016, condemned Israeli settlements in the occupied Palestinian territories as illegal, and urged a stop to settlement activities. Voting with the U.S. abstention made it significant.

Resolution 2671 (2022)

Focused on the reinforcement of the ceasefire between Israel and Syria, was done under the Disengagement of Forces agreement, which ensured the safety and functioning of UNDOF. This resolution mostly fixated on the area of separation which was being highly affected by military activities which threatened both peacekeepers and residents. It also emphasized increasing safety for women through the UN's zero tolerance towards sexual exploitation and abuse.

Resolution 2689 (2023)

Resolution 2689 which was passed in 2023 focuses on mining

Resolution 2707 (2023)

Renewed sanctions placed on Yemen in 2014 via resolution 2140

Resolution 2712 (2023)

called for humanitarian pauses in Gaza, scaling up emergency supplies to be sent, and for belligerents to allow for impartial organisations such as the Red Cross and UN aid to reach the people of Gaza.

Resolution 2728 (2024)

Called for a ceasefire in the region during Ramadan.

Resolution 2734 (2024)

Reviewed and extended sanctions against Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant (Da'esh) and Al-Qaida

Resolution 2735 (2024)

Once again called for a cease in the Gaza Strip. It suggested both sides take prerogative and further the 6-week ceasefire till negotiations continue. It also restated the efficacy of the two-state solution.

Past International Actions

The Middle East conflict has involved complex and challenging diplomatic efforts, often including international mediation and peace agreements. While many conflicts persist, key resolutions have brought renewed hope that the region may eventually achieve greater stability

Sykes-Picot Agreement (1916)

This secret agreement between Britain and France, with the assent of Russia, outlined the division of the Ottoman Empire's Arab provinces into spheres of influence.⁴⁷ The agreement, which was later revealed, contributed to a sense of betrayal among Arab nationalists and is often cited as a root cause of ongoing tensions and conflicts in the region.

Balfour Declaration (1917)

Issued by the British government, the Balfour Declaration expressed support for the establishment of a "national home for the Jewish people" in Palestine. This declaration, which was later incorporated into the League of Nations' mandate for Palestine, had a significant impact on the Arab-Israeli conflict and the Palestinian struggle for self-determination.

Camp David Accords (1978)

The agreement between Egypt and Israel reached under the auspices of the United States in 1979 to conclude a peace treaty between both sides was the first to overcome a conflict between them.⁴⁸ It established diplomatic relations between the two countries and paved the way for future peace efforts.

Oslo Accords (1993)

A set of agreements between Israel and the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) to create a basis for a two-state solution to the Oslo Accords.⁴⁹ The accords didn't bring an end to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict but they were a start for recognising Palestinian rights and opening a way for peaceful coexistence.

Taif Agreement (1989)

At the end of the Lebanese Civil War, which had devastated the country for almost 15 years, the Taif Agreement, signed in Saudi Arabia, brought an end.⁵⁰ The deal came up with a power-sharing formula which accommodated Lebanon's various

⁴⁷ Sykes-Picot Agreement. The Avalon Project : The sykes-picot agreement : 1916. (n.d.).

https://avalon.law.yale.edu/20th_century/sykes.asp

⁴⁸ U.S. Department of State. (n.d.). *Camp David Accords*. U.S. Department of State.

<https://history.state.gov/milestones/1977-1980/camp-david>

⁴⁹ U.S. Department of State. (n.d.-b). *Oslo Accords*. U.S. Department of State.

<https://history.state.gov/milestones/1993-2000/oslo>

⁵⁰ The taif agreement - UN member states. (n.d.-d).

https://www.un.int/lebanon/sites/www.un.int/files/Lebanon/the_tauf_agreement_english_version_.pdf

religions and formed the basis for national reconciliation and political stability.

Doha Agreement (2012)

Qatar helped broker the Doha Agreement to bring Yemen's political crisis to an end. That resulted in a national unity government being formed and the transfer of power from President Ali Abdullah Saleh to his vice, Abdrabbuh Mansour Hadi.

Geneva II Conference (2014)

An international effort to resolve the Syrian Civil War politically was through the Geneva II Conference. Though it failed to achieve its first aim it did bring warring parties into negotiation, and it signposted the international community's determination to settle the conflict peacefully.⁵¹

Iran Nuclear Deal (2015)

Known officially as the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), it was an agreement between Iran and the P5+1 (the five permanent members of the United Nations Security Council and Germany) limiting Iran's nuclear programme in return for ending economic sanctions. The global risk of nuclear proliferation diminished as such a deal was a diplomatic success.

Abraham Accords (2020)

The Abraham Accords brought Israel's relations with Arab countries out into the open and shifted the paradigm of the Arab-Israeli conflict. On the pretext of stopping Israel's plan to annex parts of the West Bank in July 2020, the United Arab Emirates engaged in negotiations to normalize relations.⁵² Just days before Israel and the United Arab Emirates were due to sign their agreement,

a deal was announced between Israel and Bahrain to normalize relations, and the small island country joined representatives of the United Arab Emirates, Israel, and the United States on the White House lawn days later.

In a joint declaration between Morocco, Israel, and the United States in December 2020, Morocco and Israel agreed to normalize relations and the United States also became the first country to recognize Morocco's sovereignty over Western Sahara. In January 2021 Sudan signed the Abraham Accords Declaration.

⁵¹ The Geneva II Conference on Syria, first announced by us ... (n.d.-d). https://ecfr.eu/archive/page/-/Making_the_most_of_Geneva_II.pdf

⁵² U.S. Department of State. (n.d.-a). Abraham Accords. U.S. Department of State. <https://www.state.gov/the-abraham-accords/>